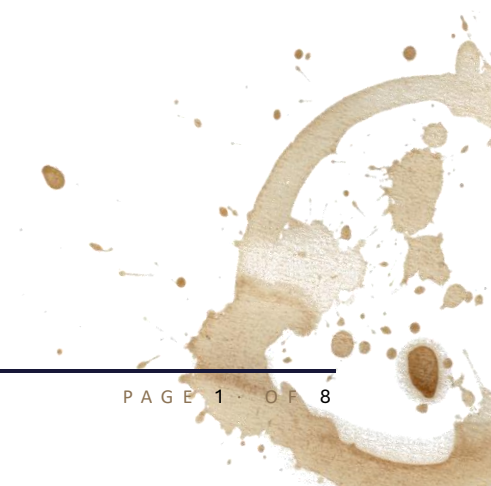

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U.S. ECONOMICS NEWS

- ◆ **Money Market Assets:** U.S. money market fund assets hit \$7.92 trillion as of September 16, 2026, up 8.8% year-over-year, even as the S&P 500 gained 14.4% over the same span, underscoring persistent investor caution despite strong equity returns.³
- ◆ **New Home Pricing:** Median new home prices fell 5.8% year-over-year to \$393,700, now down 14.5% from their October 2022 peak, as builders use incentives and smaller price-per-square-foot offerings to move inventory amid mortgage rates up roughly 100 basis points since early 2026.³
- ◆ **Trade Reshoring:** Excluding AI-related hardware, U.S. goods imports are actually down 5.3% year-to-date, while China's share of computer/electronics imports has collapsed from a 2018 peak near 50% to fifth place, with Taiwan, Mexico, Vietnam, and Thailand now leading suppliers.³
- ◆ **Capital Spending Boom:** Core capital goods shipments, a key GDP input, climbed 0.6% in August and are up 11.4% over the past year — the largest annual gain outside the COVID period since 2012, driven by hyperscaler data center spending and reshoring investment.³
- ◆ **Bond Yield Surge:** The 10-year Treasury yield climbed to 5.16% and the 30-year to 5.49%, the highest level since 2004, after a stronger-than-expected September PMI reading signaled robust business activity alongside rising input costs from energy prices.³



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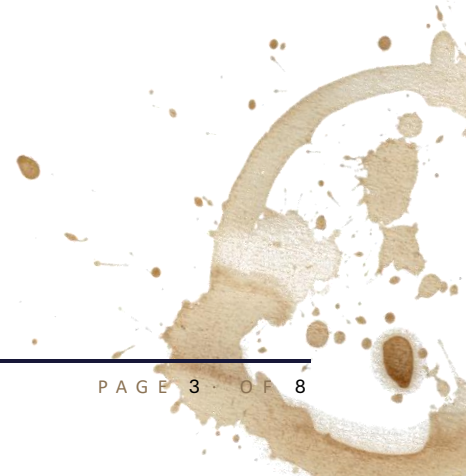
DIGITAL ASSETS NEWS

- ◆ **Bitcoin privacy:** Researchers outline a technical roadmap for integrating Zcash-style shielded transactions into Bitcoin, using zero-knowledge proofs to obscure sender, receiver, and amount data while preserving verifiability. The proposal addresses longstanding concerns about Bitcoin's transparent ledger, aiming to bring fungibility and confidentiality closer to parity with privacy-focused cryptocurrencies without sacrificing decentralization or consensus security.⁵
- ◆ **Tokenized stocks coalition:** Bullish, Alpaca, Apex, and DriveWealth have joined forces to launch an issuer-backed coalition aimed at standardizing tokenized equities, addressing regulatory compliance, custody, and settlement infrastructure to help legitimize blockchain-based stock trading and accelerate institutional adoption across traditional and crypto-native markets.⁵
- ◆ **Dollar stablecoin plan:** The Trump administration is reportedly exploring a coordinated push to expand dollar-backed stablecoins globally, aiming to reinforce the dollar's role as the world's reserve currency, extend U.S. financial influence into digital markets, and counter growing interest in alternative payment systems and central bank digital currencies from rivals like China.⁵
- ◆ **Quantum-safe costs:** Leveraging AI-assisted coding to optimize cryptographic implementations, researchers cut the estimated cost of a quantum-resistant Bitcoin transaction from roughly \$320 to just \$66 — a nearly 80% reduction — making post-quantum security measures far more economically viable for widespread blockchain adoption ahead of future quantum computing threats.⁵
- ◆ **BlackRock AI view:** BlackRock argues that autonomous AI agents needing to transact independently could become major drivers of stablecoin and broader crypto adoption, as these programmatic systems may prefer blockchain-based payment rails over traditional banking infrastructure for speed, composability, and machine-to-machine settlement, potentially accelerating institutional interest in digital assets as agentic AI use cases scale.⁵

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GEOPOLITICS NEWS

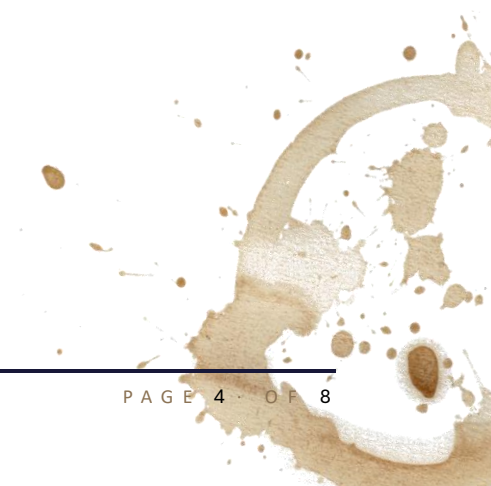
- ◆ **Germany:** Germany unveiled a roadmap to phase out fossil fuels by 2045, becoming the third country after France and the Netherlands to detail a COP28 pledge. The environment minister linked the plan directly to the Iran war's disruption of fuel supplies via the Strait of Hormuz.¹
- ◆ **Greenland:** Greenland welcomed a new US military pact reopening Cold War-era bases at Narsarsuaq and Mestersvig, expanding America's Arctic presence without the annexation Trump previously floated. Officials say trust remains fragile and work is needed to reassure a wary local population after recent unrest.¹
- ◆ **Iran:** Iranian Revolutionary Guard advisers directly helped Houthi forces seize Yemen's Red Sea coast from pro-government forces in under 48 hours, sources told AP, marking Tehran's most direct intervention in the conflict since 2014. The land grab, combined with the Saudi pipeline shutdown, boosts Iran's leverage over global oil flows.¹
- ◆ **Italy:** Italy's Senate approved legislation reintroducing nuclear power nearly 40 years after Chernobyl prompted its abandonment, part of Meloni's push for energy security. The bill sets a legal framework for next-generation reactors, though construction remains years away and voters had twice rejected nuclear power in referendums.¹
- ◆ **Russia:** Russian air strikes killed five people in Kyiv, including a 14-year-old boy, while repeated missile strikes on ArcelorMittal's Kryvyi Rih plant forced Ukraine's largest steelmaker to halt operations and expect a \$1 billion impairment, dealing a further blow to a sector that once made up 15% of exports.¹
- ◆ **Saudi Arabia:** Saudi Arabia restarted its East-West pipeline and resumed Yanbu oil exports after drone attacks forced a shutdown, lowering global prices. The Houthis claimed missile and drone strikes on Riyadh and Aramco's Yanbu facility; Saudi Arabia said it intercepted six ballistic missiles aimed at Taif and Yanbu. Saudi, Turkish and Pakistani military chiefs planned talks on supporting Riyadh.¹
- ◆ **UAE:** The UAE suspended all Iranian airline flights in compliance with new US secondary sanctions targeting Iran's aviation sector, joining Oman, Iraq, Azerbaijan, Georgia and Turkmenistan in restricting Iranian carriers, disrupting a major route for Dubai's large Iranian community and business ties.¹



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THE GOOD NEWS

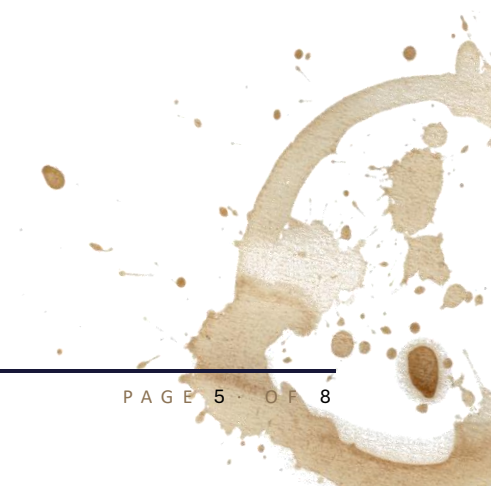
- ◆ **Smoking:** U.S. cigarette smoking has held near historic lows for five straight years, with just 11% of adults reporting they smoke, down sharply from a 1954 peak of 45%. Gallup, which has tracked the figure since 1944, found smoking has stayed below 20% since 2015, while newer nicotine pouches now stand at only 4% weekly use.²
- ◆ **Drinking:** The share of Americans who drink alcohol has hit a record low of 54% for the second year running, per Gallup's tracking since 1939. Self-reported overdrinking also fell to a new low of 13%, down from a peak of 35% in 1989, reflecting a broader long-term shift toward moderation.²
- ◆ **AI Costs:** The cost of achieving a given level of AI performance has plunged roughly 47% per quarter since 2023 — a 13-fold annual drop. That's four times faster than DNA sequencing improved, six times faster than computing power, and 54 times faster than electricity's price decline over its first century.²
- ◆ **EU Smoking:** Daily tobacco and nicotine product use across the EU edged down in 2025, with 20.8% of men and 12.6% of women now smoking daily, according to Eurostat. Both figures fell from 2022 levels of 22.2% and 13.1% respectively, continuing a gradual downward trend among adults aged 16 and older.²
- ◆ **AI Optimism:** Positive views of artificial intelligence outweigh negative ones in 34 of 37 countries surveyed so far this year by Gallup and Microsoft. Majorities in 25 countries expect AI to improve daily life, with China (93%) and Vietnam (91%) most optimistic, while Bangladesh, Egypt, and the U.S. show the least enthusiasm.²



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DIVIDEND PORTFOLIO NEWS

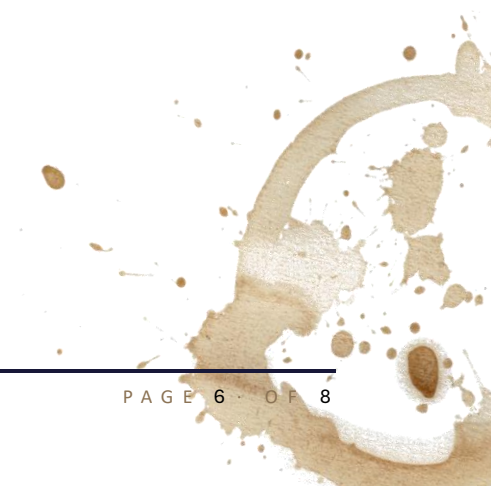
- ◆ **GD:** Defense stocks including General Dynamics slipped after Trump raised the possibility of an Iran peace deal at the UN, reducing near-term geopolitical risk premiums priced into defense contractors.⁴
- ◆ **LMT:** Lockheed shares fell alongside defense peers on Iran peace-deal speculation, but company-specific news stayed active: Mexico ordered a second C-130 Super Hercules, GE Aerospace expanded military helicopter support in Poland, and Lockheed Martin Ventures joined a \$175M PIPE for eVTOL cargo drone maker Elroy Air. A report also surfaced that F-35 stealth-coated parts were diverted to Hong Kong and seized by China, raising supply-chain security concerns.⁴
- ◆ **QCOM:** Qualcomm renewed its patent license agreement with Apple. The company also unveiled agentic on-device AI at its Snapdragon Summit, launched Snapdragon Sound Elite Gen 2 targeting AI wearables, acquired robotics software firm PickNik, and partnered with Mercedes-Benz and Wayve on autonomous driving technology.⁴



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GROWTH PORTFOLIO NEWS

- ◆ **HOOD:** Robinhood confirmed service recovery following an AWS EC2 outage that briefly disrupted trading. Separately, Deutsche Bank said tokenized capital markets could become core financial infrastructure by the 2030s, a structural tailwind for Robinhood's crypto/tokenization ambitions.⁴
- ◆ **HUT:** Hut 8 closed a \$1.07B revolving credit facility, strengthening its balance sheet for mining and AI infrastructure expansion.⁴
- ◆ **NOW:** ServiceNow shares came under pressure after Meta launched a new Enterprise Platform to compete for corporate software clients, tapping outgoing MongoDB CEO Dev Ittycheria (Desai) to lead it.⁴
- ◆ **NVDA:** Nvidia announced a massive \$150B increase to its buyback program, though it failed to lift broader chip stocks amid Iran tensions and valuation-reset debates from JPMorgan and Goldman. Anthropic's cloud/neocloud contracts with Nvidia also topped \$180B.⁴
- ◆ **NXPI:** NXP's joint venture with VIS, VSMC, opened a \$7.8B 300mm wafer fab in Singapore, expanding advanced semiconductor manufacturing capacity.⁴
- ◆ **SOFI:** SoFi went live with stablecoin settlement across Mastercard's payment network, sending shares higher and marking a significant step in its fintech/crypto infrastructure buildout, positioning it competitively in digital payments innovation.⁴
- ◆ **TSM:** TSMC reportedly raised its 2nm wafer production outlook by 20%, signaling strong advanced-node demand from AI and smartphone customers.⁴
- ◆ **VST:** Vistra and utilities broadly hit their most oversold level in three years, reflecting sector-wide pressure despite continued AI-driven power demand narratives supporting long-term bullish utility theses.⁴



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SUMMARY

In regard to the United States Economy, money market fund assets reached \$7.92 trillion, up 8.8% year-over-year, even as stocks gained 14.4%, showing investor caution. New home prices fell 5.8% to \$393,700, now 14.5% below their 2022 peak, as builders offer incentives amid higher mortgage rates. Core capital goods shipments rose 11.4% annually, the strongest pace since 2012, while the 10-year Treasury yield climbed to 5.16%, its highest since 2004, on strong PMI data.

In the world of digital assets, researchers unveiled a roadmap to bring Zcash-style shielded transactions to Bitcoin using zero-knowledge proofs for added privacy. Bullish, Alpaca, Apex, and DriveWealth formed a coalition to standardize tokenized equities. The Trump administration is reportedly exploring expanding dollar-backed stablecoins globally to reinforce dollar dominance. Separately, AI-assisted coding cut quantum-resistant Bitcoin transaction costs nearly 80%, while BlackRock argued autonomous AI agents could become major drivers of stablecoin adoption.

Recently around the globe, Germany unveiled a plan to phase out fossil fuels by 2045, citing Iran war disruptions. Greenland welcomed a new US military pact reopening Arctic bases. Iranian advisers helped Houthi forces seize Yemen's Red Sea coast, while Saudi Arabia restarted pipeline flows after drone attacks. Italy approved legislation reintroducing nuclear power, Russian strikes killed civilians in Kyiv and halted Ukraine's largest steel plant, and the UAE suspended Iranian flights amid sanctions.

For the good news, U.S. cigarette smoking has held near historic lows for five years, at just 11% of adults versus a 1954 peak of 45%. Americans who drink alcohol hit a record low of 54%, with overdrinking also at a new low. AI performance costs have plunged roughly 47% per quarter since 2023, far outpacing past technology declines. Positive views of AI outweigh negative ones in 34 of 37 countries surveyed.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, General Dynamics and Lockheed Martin shares slipped after Trump raised the possibility of an Iran peace deal, reducing geopolitical risk premiums priced into defense stocks. Lockheed saw active news, including a Mexican order for a second C-130, Poland helicopter expansion, and a \$175M eVTOL drone investment. Qualcomm renewed its Apple patent license, unveiled agentic on-device AI, acquired robotics firm PickNik, and partnered with Mercedes-Benz on autonomous driving.

And, for the growth portfolio, Robinhood confirmed recovery from an AWS outage, while Deutsche Bank said tokenized markets could become core infrastructure by the 2030s. Hut 8 closed a \$1.07B credit facility as UBS backed data-center stocks. Nvidia announced a \$150B buyback, ServiceNow fell on Meta's new enterprise platform, NXP's JV opened a Singapore fab, SoFi launched stablecoin settlement via Mastercard, TSMC raised its 2nm outlook, and Vistra hit a three-year oversold low.

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RESOURCES

- ◆ Research accumulated from <https://www.patreon.com/cw/PeterZeihan>, <https://x.com/>, and <https://seekingalpha.com/>
- ◆ <https://newsletter.humanprogress.org/>
- ◆ Research accumulated from <https://www.ftportfolios.com/> and <https://bravosresearch.com/research/>
- ◆ <https://seekingalpha.com/>
- ◆ <https://www.coindesk.com/latest-crypto-news>

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